

Cover story **MAOIST TERROR**

course adopted since last year' but senior Home Ministry officials are already signaling a rethink in their six-year strategy of parachuting central troops to 'reclaim' Maoist territory. "We will now only go only for operations based only on specific and reliable intelligence," an official says.

Maoists took advantage of the lack of a single-minded drive against them, hopping between state boundaries. So if Andhra Pradesh acted against the Maoists, they would cross over into Orissa. This is what seems to be happening now. States like Jharkhand and Bihar don't see eye to eye with the

Centre on the Maoists. Jharkhand chief minister Shibu Soren is believed to have been elected with the help of Maoists while Nitish Kumar was playing it safe with elections due in his state later this year. Soren got into talks with the Maoists and released their jailed colleagues in exchange for a kidnapped official.

Chidambaram had been trying to put pressure on the states since Green Hunt was launched. He has called three conferences of Chief Ministers on the issue, made 12 trips to the worst naxal-affected states like Jharkhand, West Bengal, Chhattisgarh and Orissa in an attempt to build a consensus on operations against the Maoists. With the new political unanimity for firm action against the Red scourge



MAHADEO SEN

AN INDOCTRINATION CAMP OF MAOISTS IN JHARKHAND



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TERROR

**THE
BEST
VERDICT**

The India Today Board assesses what went wrong in the Dantewada ambush and suggests



BRAHMA CHELLANEY
Professor, Strategic Studies, Centre for Policy Studies

- Corrupt politics, poor governance, class and caste inequity
- Decentralisation of power has created variations in social and economic conditions across India



AJIT KUMAR DOVAL
Former Director, Intelligence Bureau

- It was a massive field intelligence failure
- Significant tactical upgrade in coordination, synchronisation and deployment of the attack



MAJOR-GEN (RETD) V.K. DATTA
Former DDG MO (Special Operations)

- Little effort by CRPF to develop intelligence
- The rebels have graduated from guerrilla warfare to mobile warfare
- Little knowledge of Maoist tactics



KIRAN BEDI
Former Director-General, Bureau of Police Research and Development

- All aspects of operational assault and preventive measures were overlooked
- Naxals use policemen as cannon fodder to embarrass the government



G. PARTHASARATHY
Former High Commissioner to Pakistan

- Poor planning, intelligence and inadequacy of fire-power and equipment
- Lack of adequate training in jungle warfare and counter-insurgency



AMITABH MATTOO
Professor, International Politics, JNU

- Colossal failure of intelligence as forces could not detect large numbers of Maoists
- Forces did not have bare minimum of road opening parties that detect IEDs

**WHAT
NEEDS
TO BE
DONE**

- The arms inflow taking place from China via Myanmar must be tackled
- Deploy all possible force including air power to flush out the Maoists from the jungles

- Target Naxal source of weapons, explosives and finance
- Raise more battalions to employ local youth
- Counter Maoist ideology through outreach efforts

- Build a good regional intelligence network
- Win hearts and minds of the local population and start development in the area
- Isolate Maoist logistic bases

- An apolitical national strategy is needed
- Declare special security zones in all six affected Naxal states—West Bengal, Orissa, Andhra Pradesh, Bihar, Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh

- Equip paramilitary with adequate and superior firepower
- Involve army officers and ex-servicemen proactively in training and higher command

- Government should revisit each part of disarm-develop-dialogue strategy
- Minimise collateral damage and not use air force
- Establish dialogue with Maoists